Taoist Art through Zhuangzi and the Tao Te Ching

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Taoism is a school of thought which has remained prominent throughout Chinese history, remaining influential for thousands of years past its creation in 500 B.C. Through its longstanding prominence in China, Taoism has become a significant aspect of Chinese history and has therefore been represented in a variety of cultural artifacts, including great works of art. Artistic mediums are records of historical circumstance, and those reflecting Taoist thought can allow witnesses to perceive and consider representations of Taoist ideas. Three works of art: *The Pleasures of Fishes*, *Outing to Zhang Gong's Grotto*, and *Boulder With Daoist Paradise*, are all significant works housed in the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York City that are all cited to have significant Taoist influence. A closer examination of Taoist art through the lens of the Taoist texts can provide concrete applications of Taoist values in visual representations of thought and experience.

The *Laozi*, also known as the *Tao Te Ching*, is one of the central texts of Taoism along with the *Zhuangzi.* The *Tao Te Ching* provides instruction to both the leadership and the people to, respectively, create a harmonious society and strive for individual self-cultivation. There are some common themes within the *Tao Te Ching* that consequently suggest greater themes of Taoism, such as a distance from false dichotomies, the significance of nature, and the value of nonaction. *Zhuangzi* similarly expresses the themes that shape Taoism, but does so through stories rather than maxims. Taoist themes are established as virtues through which to achieve the *Tao*, sometimes called the Way, which would consequently indicate reaching enlightenment. The *Tao* is abstract and impossible to definite absolutely, which is part of its nature; the *Tao* is a metaphysical force which is the product of the non-discrete, yet complementary, ideas of *yin* and

yang[1]. The *Tao* can best be understood as the natural Way of the universe; a Way that will occur absent of human interference; a Way to strive for; and a Way that operates through the *qi*, which is the energy that guides all in the universe. Through the *Tao*, individuals reach enlightenment and communities reach total harmony. The *Tao Te Ching* is a work that explores the rules necessary to achieve the *Tao* and emphasizes the principles of Taoism. Examining Taoist art through the formulative ideals of the *Zhuangzi* and *Tao Te Ching* will provide a greater understanding of Taoism, one of the most significant cultural influences of Chinese history.

The Pleasures of Fishes

The Pleasures of Fishes was created on paper with ink-wash by Zhou Dongqing in 1291 and is said to be inspired by a passage from *Zhuangzi*. In this passage, Zhuangzi walks along a river and says: “See how the minnows come out and dart around where they please! That’s what fish really enjoy!”, to which Huizi responds: “You’re not a fish–how do you know what fish enjoy?” (Zhuangzi, 2020). Zhuangzi says: “You are not I, so how do you know I don’t know

[1] *Yin* and *Yang* are concepts which originated in China in the 3rd century BCE. There are a multitude of properties each quality is associated with, and they coincide as opposite forces, inseparable yet antithetical. *Yin* is found in concepts such as feminine energy; dark; water; cold; passive; even numbers; old; poor; soft; moon; and provides spirit to all things. *Yang* is found in masculine energy; light; fire; active; odd numbers; rich; sun; and provides form to all things (Cartwright & Carter, 2023).

what fish enjoy?" (Zhuangzi, 2020). In this story, Zhuangzi remarks on the pleasure and happiness of the harmonious fish, darting around freely in their ecosystem. After Huizi questions Zhuangi, asking how Zhuangzi would know what the fish enjoy; Zhuangzi uses Huizi's logic against him. This passage from *Zhuangzi* can be understood as Zhuangzi presenting the fault in logic and over-intellectualization, a common theme in Taoism that coincides with inaction. Taoist thought frequently criticizes false rationalizations, and Zhuangzi here effectively dismisses Huizi's argument in the same way Huizi falsely dismisses his.

Zhou responds to this Taoist story in *The Pleasures of Fishes.* The painting in itself emphasizes the value in considering what the fish enjoy in agreement with Zhuangzi. Further, the inscription reads "Not being fish, how do we know their happiness? / But we may express our feelings in our painting. / In order to probe the subtleties of the ordinary, / We must describe the indescribable" (Zhou 1291). The colors are muted and the subject intentionally semi-present, which follows the theme of the inscription: the experiences of the fish are out of reach, yet their image are still perceptible to any witness; while the spirit of the fish is unknown, their form is before us. Zhou likens this to art: expression is a mode through which to consider the otherwise out-of-reach; the unavailable can be explored even if it cannot be grasped. The "subtleties of the ordinary" are available only through "[describing] the indescribable", Zhou writes (1291). The "subtleties of the ordinary" indicates observable, yet non-obvious, aspects of our common surroundings, and these can only be understood through the oxymoronic practice of putting the unfathomable into understanding (Zhou 1291). These ideas emphasize the Taoist ideas of separation–in that the *Tao* cannot be forced through effort, rather found through inaction–and the harmony of life and nature.

Outing to Zhang Gong's Grotto

Outing to Zhang Gong's Grotto, painted in the 1700s, is considered one of Zhu Ruoji', better known as Shitao[2]'s, most significant masterpieces[3]. Grottos, in the Taoist belief, are important natural monuments: they represent sources of an abundance of nature's creative force and present potential for healing and renewal (Zhu 1700). At the end of the scroll, Shitao includes a long poem that attributes the mysticism of the *Tao* to the cave and indicates that his work expresses the physical manifestation of the cave in itself and the creative force that the *Tao* provides to the cave (Zhu 1700). Shitao uses an abundance of color and form to express the vivacity and expanse of the cave. The grotto becomes a subject of both beauty and mysticism; through the physical depiction of the cave, Shitao emphasizes aesthetic prominence, as in the *yang*, and, through a poetic exploration and expansive, technical deliberation, Shitao additionally portrays the *yin*. This painting is Taoist in its inspiration, execution, and interpretation: through the overlapping stratification of these complimentary ideas, the *Tao* is expressed.

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[2] "Shitao ('Stone Wave'), a scion of the Ming imperial family, became a monk and a painter after the Manchu conquest of 1644. After many years of wandering from place to place in the south and spending nearly three years in Beijing, he 'returned home'to Yangzhou toward the end of 1692" (The Metropolitan Museum of Art).

[3] From the Metropolitan Museum of Art commentary: "Zhang Gong's grotto, a famous scenic spot and once the abode of Zhang Daoling (Zhang Gong; 2nd century A.D.), a patriarch of the Daoist church, is located near Lake Tai in Jiangsu Province, not far from the pottery center of Yixing" (Zhu 1700).

In the center of the scroll (above), a man can be seen looking up at the grotto. The man is still as colored as his surroundings, and he does not shrink below the magnificence of the cave; rather, he remains a small, yet present, aspect of the painting. Taoist art is not without human influence–rather, Taoism focuses on the significance of personal improvement and harmony. The man in the painting is looking up, a direction he would have intentionally chosen, to admire the grotto around him, which subsequently suggests an admiration for the creative force of the *Tao*, which would affect its witnesses, including Shitao, who was inclined to create this scroll from its beauty. Additionally, the man is alone, in reclusion–a theme that Shitao followed in his life and portrayed in his art as an expression of the Taoist value of isolation. The painting therefore displays the monumental influence of the grotto, while maintaining the place of the individual and the subsequent harmony of the ecosystem.

Boulder With Daoist Paradise

Boulder With Daoist Paradise is a sculpture created in the 18th century by an unknown artist. All three of these works of art express Taoist ideas, but this final artwork has a more precise focus on the religious aspect of Taoism, which can be considered both, distinctly or not, a

religion and a philosophy. Religious Taoism is distinguished by its belief in and polytheistic worship of gods, which are deities that fulfill various purposes, and *xian*, which are immortal and powerful beings. *Boulder With Daoist Paradise* portrays a Taoist paradise: a mountain range decorated with nature and inhabited with immortals. Cranes and deer move about the landscape with pines, a waterfall, a pavilion, a peach tree beside it (Paradise 1700). Lower down the mountain, a servant provides a platter filled with "peaches of immortality" to two bearded individuals (Paradise 1700). The mountain is mystical for its abundance of unfathomable nature, immortals, and intricacy; the artist details the scene with trailing, heavy clouds and sleek, majestic animals. The jade which the sculpture was carved from represents "moral virtue and immortality" (Paradise 1700). Virtue by way of enlightenment and longevity are Taoist themes reflected in this art. The scene is somewhat shrouded and depicts Taoist deities, as well as emphasizing Taoist themes of reclusion, harmony, and the natural world.

Conclusion

Through a careful consideration of Taoist art, themes of Taoism can be better understood. *The Pleasures of Fishes*, *Outing to Zhang Gong's Grotto*, and *Boulder With Daoist Paradise* are all artwork with significant Taoist influence that have been considered by art historians to be some of the greatest Taoist artworks. These works help audiences better understand the personal, cultural, and social significance of Taoism, both in a historical lens, and in a contemporary consideration of Taoist thought. The themes of duality through the destruction of false dichotomies; harmony through moral society; the enlightenment of the individual through inaction and the *Tao*; and the beauty of nature and reclusivity are themes that serve the foundation of the *Zhuangzi* and the *Tao Te Ching* that ascertain the formation and interpretation of these three artworks.

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